

He can do accents, he can do faces, he can do characters. That's just three reasons why the *Bheja Fry* star has gone from being a minor relish to big cheese.

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

There's little about Vinay Pathak that screams Bollywood hero. His hair stand on end, parted in the middle into a dozen question marks. His mobile eyebrows tend to leap out of his fashionable spectacles, moving in tandem with his toothy smile. His physique, even after losing 20 kg in a year, retains the incipient chubbiness of one of his non-screen roles, Pudgy's Chicken, for a store for \$75 (Rs 2,900) an hour in New York. And his accent, even 12 years after knocking on Mumbai's doors, betrays 10 years of a Bhojpur-born boy trying to blend into multicultural America.

Yet, at 40 after 13 films, he has not-so-suddenly become an overnight sensation, demanding and commanding Rs 30-50 lakh in big budget movies. Earlier this year, a wacky comedy called *Bheja Fry*, made for Rs 1 crore, grossed Rs 21 crore at the box office. His performances in two recent low scoring but highly appreciated movies (think *Manorama—Six Feet Under* and *Johnny Gaddar*, and not the odious *Buddha Mar Gaya* which required him to shoot for half-a-day in his underwear) have won him critical raves. He's now looking at one-movie-release-a-month for the next five months. And he is currently shooting for a film, *Oh My God* where he is the hero, directed by former Ram Gopal Varma associate Saurabh Srivastava, and preparing for another directed by former roommate Parvati (*Rules: Pyar ka Superhit Formula*) Balagopalan, where he is cast opposite the delectable Gul Panag.

Quite a stretch from selling real estate to rich Americans in Long Island, one of the several odd jobs he held while studying theatre at the State University of New York at Stonybrook. Or even playing the heroine's friend from New Zealand or the hero's best friend from America, roles which came to him in droves—and which he rejected in equal measure—after he was first noticed in 1999 in Sanjay

OVERNIGHT STAR: Once struggling, Pathak now commands Rs 30-50 lakh per film



Leela Bhansali's *Hum Dil De Chuke Sanam*. Whether he is co-hosting *Ranvir, Vinay Aur Kaun?* on Star One, or being the cricket-crazed father in ESPN's promotionals, Pathak's happy-sad face is everywhere. He's a character-actor who could be a star.

And he couldn't have come at a better time for Bollywood, where there is now space for the weirdly wonderful, whether it is Boman Irani or Paresh Rawal. It is no accident that Pathak was part of last year's biggest sleeper hit, *Khosla ka Ghosla*, made for Rs 3 crore and grossed Rs 8 crore, and that his appearance on screen usually elicits an anticipatory giggle. In Bollywood's small world, Pathak is part of a creative clique that encompasses actor-director

Rajat Kapoor to his actor-friend Ranvir Shorey—one that dates back to the days when none of them had work and would spend time cooking small and dreaming big. Says Shorey, who invariably gets called Vinay and vice versa, "We've been friends now for 10 years and will always find a way to work together, whether it is touring with our play, *C for Clown*, or trying to make a movie which Vinay and I have co-written with a friend of ours who passed away." It's a clique that in another era, would have remained on the periphery of Bollywood, moving from one NFDC film to an IPTA play, living in an alternative universe of much praise and absolute penury. As Sudhir Mishra, who cast Pathak as an assistant director in